

Main Idea & Details

Grade 3 Reading Comprehension Worksheet

Paragraph 1

Bees are small insects that do big jobs. They fly from flower to flower and drink sweet nectar. As they fly, tiny grains of pollen stick to their legs. The bees carry the pollen to other flowers, which helps new plants grow. Back at the hive, bees turn nectar into honey. They store the honey in wax combs to eat in winter.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Bees help plants grow and make honey.
- b. Bees drink sweet nectar.
- c. Honey is stored in wax combs.

2. What do bees carry on their legs from flower to flower?

Paragraph 2

Our town library is full of books. You can borrow picture books, storybooks, and books about animals. Each person may take home five books at a time. A librarian stamps the date the books must come back. There are also puzzles, computers, and a quiet corner for reading. Best of all, borrowing books is free.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. A librarian stamps the books.
- b. The library is a free place to borrow books and read.
- c. The library has puzzles.

4. How many books may each person take home at a time?

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Sea turtles spend most of their lives in the ocean. They swim with strong flippers and can hold their breath for a long time. Mother turtles crawl onto sandy beaches at night to lay their eggs. They dig a deep hole, drop in about one hundred eggs, and cover them with sand. Then they swim back to the sea and never see their babies.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Turtles have strong flippers.
 - b. Sea turtles live in the ocean and lay eggs on beaches.
 - c. Mother turtles lay eggs at night.

2. About how many eggs does a mother turtle lay?

Paragraph 2

Rain starts high in the sky. Heat from the sun lifts water from lakes and oceans into the air. The water cools and turns into tiny drops that form clouds. When the drops grow heavy, they fall back to the ground as rain. Rain fills rivers and lakes and helps plants grow. Without rain, the earth would be dry and brown.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Clouds are made of tiny drops.
 - b. The sun is hot.
 - c. Rain is part of a cycle that brings water back to the earth.

4. What lifts water from lakes and oceans into the air?

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Paragraph 1

Dogs are more than pets. Some dogs help people who cannot see. These guide dogs learn to stop at curbs and walk around objects in the way. Other dogs sniff out lost hikers in the mountains. Farm dogs help move sheep from one field to another. All of these dogs work hard and are trained for many months.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Sheep live on farms.
 - b. Dogs are good pets.
 - c. Dogs can be trained to do many helpful jobs.

2. What do guide dogs do at curbs?

Paragraph 2

Last spring our class planted a garden behind the school. We dug the soil, dropped in seeds, and watered them every day. Soon green sprouts pushed up through the dirt. By summer we had red tomatoes, long carrots, and yellow squash. We shared the vegetables with the lunchroom. Gardening taught us that hard work pays off.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Tomatoes are red.
 - b. The lunchroom is big.
 - c. Our class grew vegetables in a school garden.

4. What three vegetables did the class grow?

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Paragraph 1

Many people fear spiders, but spiders are helpful. They spin sticky webs to catch flies and other bugs. A spider has eight legs and two main body parts. Most spiders cannot hurt people at all. Some spiders do not even spin webs. Wolf spiders chase their food on the ground, and jumping spiders can leap many times their own length.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Spiders have eight legs.
 - b. Flies are annoying.
 - c. Spiders are helpful because they catch insects.

2. How do spiders catch flies and other bugs?

Paragraph 2

Taking care of your teeth keeps them strong. Brush twice a day with a soft brush and toothpaste. Floss gently between teeth to remove bits of food. Try not to eat too many sweets, because sugar can cause cavities. Visit the dentist two times each year for a cleaning and a checkup. Baby teeth fall out to make room for grown-up teeth, which must last your whole life.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Brush twice a day.
 - b. Good habits keep your teeth healthy.
 - c. Baby teeth fall out.

4. How often should you visit the dentist?

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Paragraph 1

Ants live and work together in large groups called colonies. Each ant has a job. Worker ants dig tunnels and carry food back to the nest. Soldier ants guard the entrances. The queen ant lays all the eggs. Ants can lift objects many times heavier than their own bodies. They talk to each other by touching feelers and leaving scent trails.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. The queen ant lays all the eggs.
 - b. Ants work together, and each ant has a job.
 - c. Ants are very strong.

2. What do worker ants do?

Paragraph 2

In winter the days grow short and the air turns cold. Water in the clouds freezes into tiny crystals that fall as snow. Snow covers the ground like a soft white blanket. Children build snowmen and sled down hills. Animals like bears sleep through the cold months in warm dens. Birds that cannot find food fly south to warmer places.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Winter brings cold, snow, and changes for people and animals.
 - b. Children build snowmen.
 - c. Bears sleep in dens.

4. Why do some birds fly south in winter?

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Paragraph 1

Every day mail carriers bring letters and packages to our homes. The journey starts at the post office, where workers sort the mail by street and house number. Trucks and planes carry the mail across the country. A letter can travel thousands of miles in just a few days. Long ago, mail traveled by horse over deserts and mountains.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Horses are fast.
- b. Mail travels through many steps to reach our homes.
- c. Trucks carry the mail.

2. How did mail travel long ago?

Paragraph 2

Frogs begin life as tiny eggs in the water. The eggs hatch into tadpoles with long tails and no legs. Tadpoles swim and eat plants in the pond. Slowly they grow legs, and their tails shrink away. At last they become frogs that can hop on land and swim in water. A frog's sticky tongue can shoot out to catch flies.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Frogs live near water.
- b. Tadpoles have long tails.
- c. Frogs change shape as they grow from eggs to adults.

4. What do tadpoles eat?

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Paragraph 1

Running, swimming, and biking make your body strong. When you exercise, your heart beats faster and pumps blood to your muscles. Strong muscles help you run farther and climb higher. Exercise also helps your brain. Children who play outside every day can focus better in class. You do not need special gear. A ball, a jump rope, or just a pair of shoes is enough. Try to play for one hour each day.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Daily exercise makes your body and brain strong.
 - b. A jump rope is fun.
 - c. Hearts beat faster.

2. How long should you try to play each day?

Paragraph 2

Camels are built for the hot desert. Their wide feet do not sink into soft sand. Long eyelashes keep sand out of their eyes. The hump on a camel's back stores fat, which the camel's body can turn into energy and water. Camels can go many days without a drink. People call camels the ships of the desert because they carry heavy loads across the sand.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?
 - a. Deserts are hot.
 - b. Camels carry heavy loads.
 - c. Camels have special body parts that help them live in the desert.

4. What does a camel's hump store?

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Paragraph 1

Reading opens doors to new worlds. Books can take you to deep oceans, outer space, or long-ago times. When you read, you learn new words and new ideas. Good readers ask questions as they read. Who is this about? What will happen next? The more you read, the stronger your reading muscles grow. Try reading for twenty minutes before bed.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Reading takes you to new places and makes you smarter.
- b. Books have many words.
- c. Bedtime is quiet.

2. How long should you try to read before bed?

Paragraph 2

Deep under the earth, rock is so hot that it melts. This melted rock is called magma. When pressure builds up, magma pushes up through cracks in the ground. It bursts out as red-hot lava. The lava cools and hardens into new rock, building up a mountain called a volcano. Some volcanoes erupt with loud booms and clouds of ash.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Lava is red-hot.
- b. Scientists are smart.
- c. Volcanoes form when hot melted rock pushes up through the earth.

4. What is melted rock under the earth called?

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Paragraph 1

On Saturday mornings the farmer's market fills the town square. Farmers set up tables with fresh apples, corn, eggs, and honey. Bakers sell warm bread and sweet pies. Musicians play songs while shoppers walk from stall to stall. Everything sold at the market is grown or made close to home. The fruits and vegetables are picked ripe, so they taste better.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Musicians play songs.
- b. The farmer's market sells fresh local food on Saturday mornings.
- c. Pies are sweet.

2. When does the farmer's market fill the town square?

Paragraph 2

Penguins are birds that cannot fly. Instead, their wings work like flippers, and they are excellent swimmers. Penguins live in cold places near the South Pole. They huddle together in big groups to stay warm in icy winds. Mother and father penguins take turns keeping their egg warm on their feet. Baby penguins are called chicks.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Penguins huddle to stay warm.
- b. Chicks are cute.
- c. Penguins are swimming birds that live in cold places.

4. What are baby penguins called?

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Paragraph 1

Bridges help people cross rivers, valleys, and busy roads. The first bridges were simple logs laid across streams. Later, people built bridges from stone arches that could hold heavy carts. Today engineers build long steel bridges that carry cars and trains. Building a bridge takes careful planning to make sure it is strong enough.

1. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Stone bridges hold carts.
- b. Engineers plan carefully.
- c. Bridges have changed over time but all help people cross over obstacles.

2. What were the first bridges made of?

Paragraph 2

Recycling turns old things into new things. Used paper can become new notebooks. Melted glass jars can become new bottles. Plastic bottles can be spun into warm jackets. Recycling saves trees, energy, and space in landfills. You can help by sorting paper, glass, and plastic into the right bins. Before you recycle, rinse out jars and bottles.

3. What is the main idea of this paragraph?

- a. Jackets are warm.
- b. Glass jars become bottles.
- c. Recycling turns old materials into new products and helps the earth.

4. What should you do before recycling jars and bottles?
